

A beginner's guide to MMA terminology

New to MMA? Learn the key UFC terms, rules, scoring methods and fight jargon so you can follow every moment inside the Octagon.

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Mixed Martial Arts (MMA) is one of the fastest-growing sports on the planet, but for a newcomer, the commentary can sound like a foreign language.

In an effort to decode some of the more peculiar words heard cageside and elsewhere, we have compiled this UFC glossary to ensure you never lose your footing when the cage door closes.

Dictating terms: Ground and pound on display as Islam Makhachev of Russia takes his opponent to the canvas and unleashes strikes.

GETTY IMAGES

BASICS

The Octagon: The trademarked eight-sided caged enclosure where UFC bouts take place.

The Unified rules: The standard set of rules governing MMA, covering everything from illegal strikes, such as eye pokes, to how rounds are scored.

Weight classes: Divisions ranging from Strawweight (115 lbs) to Heavyweight (up to 265 lbs). Fighters often undergo weight cuts to meet

these limits before a bout.

Main event: Usually the final fight of the night, scheduled for five five-minute rounds, whereas standard bouts are contested over three rounds.

STRIKING TERMINOLOGY

Southpaw vs Orthodox: An Orthodox fighter stands with their left hand and foot forward (typically right-handed), while a Southpaw leads with their right (typically left-handed).

Clinch: When fighters move into close quarters and grab one another to deliver knees or elbows, or to set up a takedown.

